

Section A.

Fair trade, not free trade.

Manchester, New Hampshire · 2016

In 2016, Donald Trump went to a packed rally in Manchester, New Hampshire. He told the crowd that the days of "free trade" were over. He promised something he called "fair trade" instead.

This part of the book shows you four things in plain English. What he said that night. Why he said it. What actually happened over the next four years. And where he had to back off the promise.

We don't tell you whether he kept it or broke it. The book gives you the words, the documents, and the story. The score is yours.

TIME:
Evening ·
general-election
phase

PLACE:
Manchester,
New
Hampshire

SETTING:
Arena rally
·
post-primary
campaign
push

AUDIENCE:
Battleground
crowd ·
~thousands
(broadcast
+ floor)

Verbatim

"We are going to make America rich again... It starts with trade — fair trade, not free trade."

Campaign rally · Manchester, NH · 2016 (verbatim excerpt)

What shaped the promise

The crowd that night was full of people whose old factory jobs were gone. For decades, both parties had told them that was just how the world worked. Trump said something different. He told them the rules of trade were rigged against American workers, and he would change them.

He was also picking a fight inside his own party. Big Republican donors had backed "free trade" for years. By saying "fair, not free," Trump made it harder for anyone in the party to walk the promise back later.

At a glance: two ways to think about trade

FREE TRADE — the way it was

- Lower tariffs
- Big multi-country deals
- Markets decide

FAIR TRADE — what 2016 promised

- Higher tariffs on rivals
- One-on-one country deals
- America pushes for better terms

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What actually happened

Once Trump took office, his team did three big things you can read in the official record.

First, in March 2018, the White House put tariffs on imported steel and aluminum. Most countries had to pay them.

Second, between July 2018 and September 2019, the U.S. put tariffs on about \$370 billion worth of goods from China. That was the biggest tariff push by any U.S. president since the 1930s.

Third, the team replaced NAFTA — the trade deal Trump had attacked by name — with a new deal called USMCA. It was signed in November 2018 and went into effect on July 1, 2020.

Timeline: trade actions, 2018 – 2020



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Where the promise had to bend

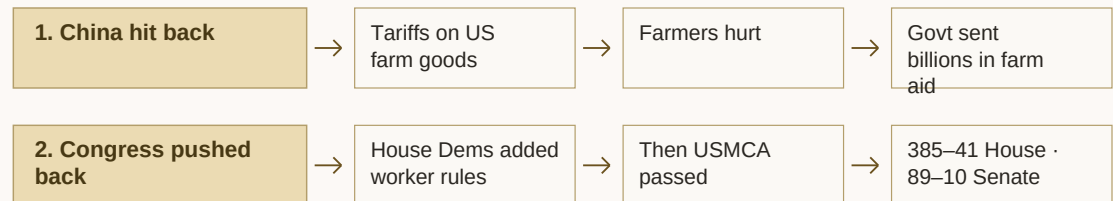
Two big things forced the promise to bend.

China hit back. They put their own tariffs on American soybeans, pork, and corn. American farmers got hurt fast. To keep them in business, the U.S. government paid out billions in emergency farm aid — money the original promise didn't plan for.

Congress pushed back. The new USMCA didn't pass right away. House Democrats added stronger worker protections first. Only then did it pass — 385 to 41 in the House, 89 to 10 in the Senate.

The 2016 promise didn't disappear. The tariffs and the new deal are still on the books. But the working idea of "fair" got smaller — fewer countries, smaller fights — than the rally line suggested.

Two pressures, in pictures



END OF SECTION

"Fair trade, not free trade."

— Manchester, New Hampshire · 2016

What's next

This is one of three sections in Chapter 3 about trade. The next two sections do the same thing for two more promises. §B covers what Trump said about China. §C covers what he said about bringing factory jobs back to America.

Each section follows the same simple pattern. The promise. The room it was made in. What really happened. Where it had to bend. And a blank line for your own grade.

Read together, Chapter 3 is one trade argument told three ways — the way it was promised, and the way it landed.